FIELD NOTES FROM THE 1893 ZELTAVIA EXPEDITION

kept by Ida Vennholt, cartographer to the Royal Northern Survey

14 April 1893. Marrow Bay.
We came ashore in a drizzle so fine it seemed to fall upwards. The harbourmaster, a patient man named Osric Pell, counted our crates twice and our instruments three times, and then asked whether we had brought any juniper. We had not. He sold us a sack at a price I suspect was invented on the spot.

Marrow Bay sits where the river Quill meets the sea, and the whole town leans slightly towards the water, as if listening to it. I estimate some nine thousand souls; Pell insists it is "twelve thousand, counting the gulls." The smokehouses along the Eel Steps never stop. Everything here, my coat included, now smells of smoked eel and juniper, which the Zeltavians assure me is the national dish and the national perfume.

16 April. The Lantern Hill.
Climbed the Lantern Hill at dawn to take our first bearings. The old signal lantern is lit every night by whichever family lost an argument in the town council that week. Tonight it is the Pells. From the summit I fixed the mouth of the Quill at 312 degrees from the lantern and the Saltglass Reef at 205 degrees. Mr Ambrose Tull, our naturalist, spent the morning arguing with a goat.

18 April. On customs.
Everyone greets us with "brennet", which I took for "good morning" until I heard it said at midnight. It means something nearer to "you are expected", and is said to strangers and to returning fishermen alike. One does not refuse a cup of quillwater tea, though one may, with great politeness, pour the second cup into a plant.

21 April 1893. Up the Quill.
We hired two flat boats and a pilot, a girl of perhaps fifteen called Maren Holloway, who knows every sandbar of the river by name. The names are mostly insults to long-dead pilots. By evening we reached Quill Ford, where the river is wide and shallow enough to wade, and where the ferry has been "temporarily out of service" since 1861.

23 April. Fog.
For two days the fog was so thick that Tull lost sight of his own boots. I navigated by dead reckoning alone: our speed from a knotted line and a sand-glass, our heading from the compass, the hours from my watch, and the rest from stubbornness. When the fog lifted on the 24th we were within a quarter mile of where I had reckoned us to be, which I record here because nobody else will.

25 April. The Juniper Steps.
North of Quill Ford the land rises in long terraces where wild juniper grows so thickly the hills look bruised blue in the evening. The Zeltavians call them the Juniper Steps and harvest the berries every September in a festival called the Knelling, at which the first basket is offered to the river and the second to whoever sings worst. Tull has volunteered for next year.

27 April. Fennick's Mill.
A water mill, long abandoned, with a wheel that still turns when the river is high. Local opinion holds that it grinds nothing and is therefore the most honest building in Zeltavia. We camped in its loft. Tull found a nest of grey owls; the owls found Tull.

2 May 1893. Saltglass Reef.
Back at the coast, we rowed out to the Saltglass Reef at low water. The reef is named for the crust of salt that glitters on its rocks at noon; sailors claim it can be seen from the Lantern Hill on a clear day, and for once the sailors are right. Three wrecks lie inside it. The newest, the Margarethe, went aground in 1879 while her captain was, by all accounts, explaining to his crew that the reef was further east.

5 May. The Grey Isles and Hollin Lighthouse.
Two days' sail west lie the Grey Isles, low and treeless, home to more puffins than people. Hollin Lighthouse stands on the largest of them. Its keeper, Widow Agathe Strand, has kept it for thirty-one years and keeps a ledger of every ship she has seen, which she would not let me copy but did let me admire.

9 May. Leaving.
Our survey is complete: the coast from Saltglass Reef to the Grey Isles, the Quill as far as Fennick's Mill, and the town of Marrow Bay itself, with every lane, smokehouse and argument I could fix on paper. Osric Pell came to the harbour to see us off and said "brennet" again, which I now understand to mean that we are expected back.

Instruments used: one theodolite (dented), two compasses, one knotted log-line, one sand-glass of thirty seconds, one pocket watch (fast by four minutes, consistently, which is the next best thing to being right).